

49 Modal verbs in the future

Some modal verbs change form when used to talk about the future. Others cannot be used in the future at all, and have to be replaced with other modal verbs or phrases.

⚙️ **New language** "Will be able to," "will have to"

Aa **Vocabulary** Legal terms

🧩 **New skill** Expressing future ability and obligation

49.1 KEY LANGUAGE "CAN" IN THE FUTURE

It is not grammatically possible to talk about the future using "can."
"Will be able to" is used instead.

At the moment, I **can** play the trombone quite well.



If I work harder, I **will be able to** play at concerts.

"Will can" is incorrect.

The negative is formed with "not able to" or "unable to."

Unfortunately, I **can't** read music very well.



If I don't learn, I **won't be able to** join the orchestra.

You can also use "will be unable to," but it's less common.



49.2 REWRITE THE SENTENCES TO REFER TO THE FUTURE

Can the police find a way to stop people from littering?

Will the police be able to find a way to stop people from littering?

1 Unfortunately, he can't pay his parking fines.

2 Can you install a security camera in the store?

3 I can't understand all these legal regulations.

4 Hopefully, my sister can explain it all to me. She's a lawyer.

